

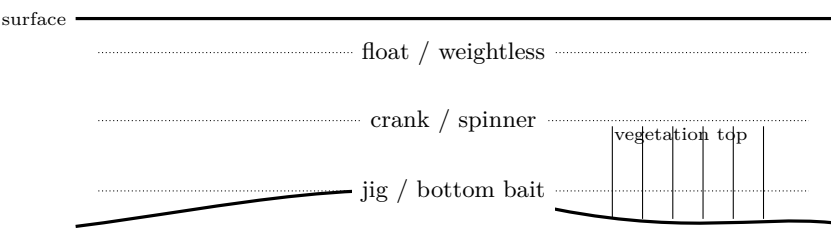
BAIT IS REGULATED

Inspect, remove, and drain before transport. Do not move live fish away from a waterbody. Put unwanted bait in trash and obey current source, water, and transport rules. Secure every exposed hook in storage.

Start with the job, not the brand

Tool	Job	Start here	First adjustment
Small jig	Depth contact; compact prey	Breaks, saddle, panfish or walleye search	Change weight to restore feel.
Slip bobber + legal bait	Hold exact depth	Vegetation edges and flats	Move stop in 1-ft steps.
Straight soft worm	Slow bass fall	Sparse cover and clear shelf edges	Weightless, then minimally weighted.
Weedless plastic	Enter vegetation	West Pine shelf; North flats	Add only enough weight to penetrate.
Crankbait	Cover a depth band	Hard edges with safe clearance	Running depth first, then speed.
Spinner / spoon	Flash and vibration	Weed lanes and active pike water	Add a bite-resistant leader when warranted.
Live minnow	Natural movement	Jig, float, or lawful predator rig	Keep lively; verify source and transport law.
Leech / crawler	Slow natural bait	Float or bottom rig	Downsize hook and use only what can be presented responsibly.

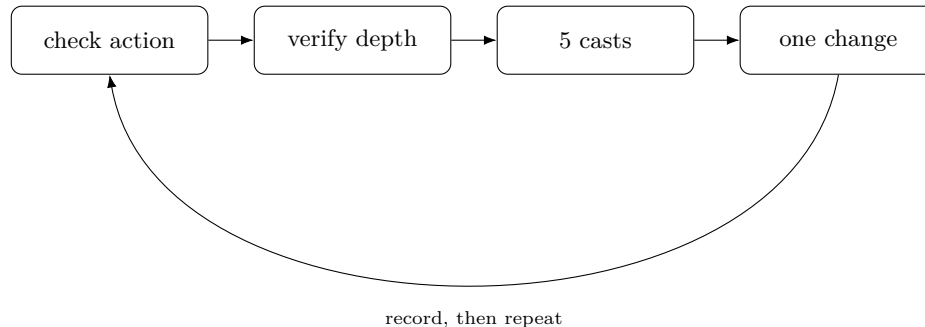
Depth-band picture



Intermediate question: Which band did the lure actually occupy? A nominal “deep” lure that fouls on weeds may spend no useful time at depth.

Tune one presentation

1. **Verify action beside the boat.** The lure runs upright; soft plastic is straight; bait can move; hook point is clear.
2. **Establish depth.** Count down a jig, measure the bobber stop, or confirm bottom contact. Record the number.
3. **Make five comparable casts.** Same lane, distance, speed, and pause. Note weed, bottom, bite, or clean water.
4. **Change one variable.** Depth by 1 ft, jig weight one step, or retrieve from steady to stop-and-go. Repeat.



Measurements that transfer

Record	How to verify
Float depth	Measure stop to hook; subtract the suspended weight/hook drop if precision matters.
Jig fall	Count seconds to first bottom touch in known depth; repeat with taut and semi-slack line.
Crank clearance	Rod tip and retrieve keep periodic bottom/weed ticks without continuous fouling.
Weed penetration	Weight enters the canopy yet comes back with the hook point clear often enough to fish efficiently.

Troubleshooting

Symptom	Corrective sequence
Lure spins	Check bent shaft, crooked plastic, fouled hook, and excessive speed beside the boat before casting again.
No bottom feel	Use thinner line or one weight step heavier; shorten cast; verify in known depth.
Every cast fouls	Inspect the actual weed-top depth; fish 1 ft above it, parallel the edge, or switch to a weedless geometry.
Live bait dies quickly	Correct temperature, oxygen, crowding, and handling; discard lawfully rather than moving it to another water.
One short strike	Inspect and sharpen/replace hook; do not instantly change three variables. Repeat the verified lane first.

Presentation passes when

It enters the intended depth band, remains correctly rigged, returns free of hidden fouling, and can be repeated within the same cast lane. Only then does a bite or no-bite compare meaningfully.

Source basis: Wisconsin DNR Hook Your Catch; Fishing for Dinner; Boat Transportation and Bait Laws.

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